

1.1 Social Networking: A Little History

You see it everywhere: for time immemorial, homo sapiens has huddled together in groups. We are gregarious animals, and we've become the dominant species on the planet much because of our habit of sharing information—and our opposable thumbs (to keep the biology majors silent).

So sit back and forget about the Internet for a while, and think about it: it all started when barely-human apes learnt to hunt in packs. Next was the discovery of fire, and our ancestors gathered in front of fires for a millennium after that. Then came cities and ships, and we traversed the globe, still huddled together for warmth and that general feeling of goodness. We've hugged each other excitedly at sports events, consoled each other in times of misery, and continually found new ways to form cuddly, warm groups of like-minded individuals. There's always been a group even the squarest of us can fit into—sort of like in a college canteen: the jocks sit together; the popular ones preen themselves at one table while the unpopular ones look on in awe; the nerds challenge each other with Mensa trivia; the anti-establishmentals are busy spray-painting the loos. You get the picture...

Then came the computer.

A PC was, and is, a very personal gadget (perhaps, just perhaps, that's why they call it a Personal Computer!). When it first became popular sometime in the '90s, it was something you could use for hours or days—but always alone. Gaming was addictive, Windows was fun to use, and MS Office let you get work done so much faster than when you still used books. We got addicted. Problem was, we ended up feeling cold and empty—a PC was fun, but it was still a dumb machine (no matter how many times it beat you at chess), and we yearned for the interaction that only other people could give us.

Then came the Internet. A far cry from the lonely machine, the PC was now able to put you in touch with people from any-